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It's a genuine honor to reach out to you, especially through Mrs. Jane Sun, to whom I'm grateful for the care she has shown me. As Mrs. Sun once wrote, "With crisis comes opportunity." At age 18, I was facing the death penalty after my parents outed me as gay, which is criminalized in Tunisia. While I was homeless and a fugitive, I worked as a server and cleaned bathrooms to afford library access. I used that access to teach myself English so I could write my college applications and submit them through public library computers, which earned me admission to Columbia University. I escaped to the United States as an international student with only the clothes on my back, and last month, I graduated from Columbia University with a Bachelor's degree in Computer Science.

While studying and working in the United States, I came to understand immigration as a lifeline, one that determined not only whether I could work and remain, but whether I could continue building the life I had crossed an ocean to save. That struggle gave me more than perseverance. It gave me the insight, urgency, and conviction to build a company whose mission is inseparable from my own. Using my years of experience in AI research and software engineering, I built Ellis AI, named after New York's historic gateway for immigrants. My hope is that this will turn all the legal obstacles I had struggled with into a more accessible, one-stop process. I wanted to address the biggest barriers I had faced - legal processes during my immigration process – and make the same dreams more accessible for those who come after me. I ultimately chose to turn down an opportunity at Google and devote myself fully to building Ellis. I hope that it would bring people the same hope the first glimpse of Ellis island would

bring immigrants upon their arrival - a promise of a better future.

Ironically, my greatest barrier is not ambition, technical readiness, or commitment. It is my immigration status and the \$260,000 in funding I must raise to build the company and support my O-1 petition. Your investment would give me more than capital. It would give me the chance to transform lived hardship into a company of lasting consequence and build for immigrants whose futures are too often determined by systems they cannot navigate alone.

If given this opportunity, I will honor it with the same perseverance that carried me from surviving on the streets of Tunisia to graduating from Columbia University in New York. I know what it means to build with almost nothing, to continue when the outcome appears impossible, and to treat every opportunity as a responsibility. I would bring that same discipline, urgency, and gratitude to every dollar entrusted to me.

Thank you for considering my story, Ellis, and a future where AI helps immigrants carry their dreams across borders. I hope you join me in building this future where ____

With utmost respect and gratitude,

Sam Nawaly Abdella